was killed by a contract assassin, who was paid Rs 50,000 to crush his skull with a hammer and stage an accident. Apparently, two villagers had tipped off the gang about Dariyab, assuring them "no one will care even if he dies". A claim of Rs 15 lakh had already been paid out.

Like Dariyab, Sanjay Kumar of Budaun seemed destined for misfortune. Paralysed and abandoned by his wife, he leaned on his younger brother, Naveen, for support. Or so he believed. On the night of June 20, 2024, the brothers set out together on an e-rickshaw. Minutes later, Sanjay was dead. At first, it was passed off as an accident, blamed on the driver's reckless speeding. But investigators soon uncovered a far darker truth. Naveen, they claim, had pushed his immobile brother out of the moving vehicle. When the terrified driver fled, he allegedly smashed Sanjay's head against the road to make sure he died.

The motive was chillingly clear. In just seven months, four insurance policies worth Rs 95 lakh had been taken out in Sanjay's name, with Naveen listed as the sole nominee. By the time the scheme unravelled, he had already pocketed Rs 20 lakh. Naveen later told police he had acted on the advice of a local lawyer. "These are not just financial frauds," says Anukriti. "These were premeditated murders, plotted months in advance. Human beings were seen as policy numbers, nothing more." So far, 15 suspects linked to the four murders have been arrested.

PLUGGING THE BLIND SPOTS

The scam's ingenuity lay in exploiting every possible loophole. Investigators found that Aadhaar records were routinely tampered with to make elderly applicants appear younger, thereby qualifying them for government schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana. Framed as a safety cushion for families, the scheme set basic conditions: age below 50 and no death within 45 days of joining. One gang that Anukriti's team busted charged as little as Rs 2,000–3,000 to alter details using manipulated devices.

In Delhi, police discovered three life insurance policies issued in the name of one Trilok Kumar, months after he died while undergoing treatment at the Rajiv Gandhi Cancer Institute and Research Centre in June 2024. One claim had even been cleared on the basis of a forged death certificate, and his file bizarrely contained an ECG dated six months after his cremation.

Fraudsters also exploited credit-linked insurance. At Behjoi police station in Sambhal, a complaint revealed how they bought tractors and motorcycles in the names of the terminally ill, knowing the loans would be cleared upon the insured person's death. The vehicles were then sold off illegally in underground mandis.

How did insurers not notice that

HOW THE NEXUS WORKED

Behind every fraudulent claim lay a finely-tuned assembly line of deception

IDENTIFYING TARGETS
ASHA workers and village functionaries flagged terminally ill patients as potential beneficiaries

APPROACHING FAMILIES
Agents posed as helpers offering government schemes, tricking households into parting with Aadhaar, PAN and medical records

FORGING DOCUMENTS
Aadhaar addresses were altered, and thumb impressions or signatures taken to initiate policies

CREATING THE TRAIL
With corrupt bank staff, accounts were opened in nominees' names and linked with black-market SIMs

POLICY CREATION
Insurance insiders and third-party investigators ensured smooth policy approvals and later cleared claims

MEDICAL & VILLAGE SIGN-OFF
Medical staff issued false treatment records; village officials validated fake death certificates

AFTER DEATH
Families, duped again, handed over certificates used to lodge claims with little scrutiny

SIPHONING PAYOUT
Control of nominee accounts allowed the nexus to withdraw insurance money through forged cheques and colluding bank staff

HARDIK CHHABRA



HOPES SWINDLED Priyanka Sharma with her children at their home in Rajpura block of Sambhal district